WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

SEYCHELLES

Africa

Information current as of November 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Victoria (Mahé)	Capital and seat of government; home to the main administrative, banking and professional-services community	Financial services, professional services, real estate
Port Victoria	The only significantly sized seaport, being deepened and extended with EIB, AFD and EU support to handle larger vessels and compete for regional tuna business	Port logistics, fisheries services, marine engineering
Mahé (main island) and Seychelles International Airport	Home to about three-quarters of the population and the main tourism and aviation gateway	Hospitality, aviation services, real estate
Praslin and La Digue	Leading secondary islands for premium and eco-tourism, where mid-sized hotels are open to foreign investment with a local partner	Boutique hospitality, eco-tourism, local services
Outer Islands	Remote coral islands offering ultra-premium, low-density resort and conservation-linked development	Luxury tourism, conservation, aviation logistics
Fisheries and industrial estates (Mahé)	Fisheries is one of the two pillars of the economy, with tuna processing at the core of the value chain	Fish processing, cold chain, packaging
Exclusive Economic Zone and marine protected areas	More than 400,000 sq km of marine protected area created through a debt-for-nature swap, under a commitment to protect 30% of the EEZ	Sustainable fisheries, aquaculture, blue finance

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Seychelles Investment Board (SIB), established in 2004 as the national single gateway for investment promotion and facilitation, helping investors obtain permits, licences and incentives
- Seychelles Investment Act 2010 and the Seychelles Investment (Economic Activities) Regulations 2022, which list activities open to foreign investors, those requiring a Seychellois partner with equity caps, and an economic needs test for others
- Seychelles International Trade Zone (SITZ), under the SITZ Act 1995, offering full foreign ownership, customs duty exemptions on certain capital equipment and certain tax exemptions
- Financial Services Authority (FSA) licensing for international business companies, funds, fund administrators and SITZ activities

- An open foreign-exchange regime with no foreign exchange restrictions, no capital gains or withholding tax, and investor protection through the ICSID and New York Conventions and an Investment Appeal Panel
- Tourism-sector entry through SIB, with hotels of more than 25 rooms open to foreign investment and smaller hotels and restaurants subject to foreign equity caps
- Blue-economy channels, building on the world's first sovereign blue bond (2018) and a debt-for-nature swap that funded marine protection

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Seychelles has the highest GNI per capita in Africa and a strong record of reform. Real GDP grew by 5.8% in 2025, according to the World Bank and IMF staff, driven by record tourist arrivals. Public debt fell to 53.6% of GDP in 2025, towards a medium-term anchor of 50%, and Fitch upgraded the sovereign to BB with a stable outlook in September 2025, citing tourism performance. In May 2026 the IMF Executive Board completed the final reviews of Seychelles' Extended Fund Facility and Resilience and Sustainability Facility. Inflation was 1.2% in September 2026, the Central Bank held its policy rate at 1.75% throughout 2025 and into the fourth quarter of 2026, and reserves cover about four months of imports. President Patrick Herminie, sworn in on 26 October 2025, leads a government focused on economic diversification.

Seychelles' main structural challenge is its reliance on tourism and on long-haul air connections: the IMF notes that about 60% of arrivals come via Doha, Dubai or Abu Dhabi. The 2026 Middle East conflict disrupted these hubs, and March arrivals fell by 37.2% year on year, so IMF staff now expect growth of about 1% in 2026. The response has been measured: the rupee and the external position have stayed broadly stable, financial-sector stress appears limited, and IMF staff report a nascent tourism recovery. The episode strengthens the case for diversification into fisheries processing, port services, blue finance and renewable energy, all areas with established institutions and development-bank support.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Tourism concentration and air-connectivity exposure	About 60% of visitors arrive via Gulf hubs, and the 2026 Middle East conflict cut arrivals sharply between March and June	A recovery is under way; investors can diversify by source market and favour projects with multiple air-route options, while new route development creates aviation and hospitality openings
Slower growth in 2026	IMF staff project growth of about 1% in 2026 after 5.8% in 2025	Completed IMF programmes, a Fitch BB rating, falling debt and stable monetary policy support a return to trend; counter-cyclical entry can secure assets and partners on favourable terms
Small domestic market	A population of about 120,000 limits the scale of domestic-market-only businesses	Position Seychelles as a premium, export- or visitor-facing base, using the SITZ and SADC and COMESA market access
Activity restrictions for foreign investors	The 2022 Economic Activities Regulations cap foreign equity in some activities, such as hotels of 16 to 24 rooms (80%) and small restaurants (49%)	Confirm eligibility with SIB early and structure partnerships with Seychellois investors where caps apply
Climate and coastal exposure	The World Bank estimates climate and environmental pressures could reduce GDP by more than 6% by 2050	The IMF Resilience and Sustainability Facility and marine-protection framework support adaptation, opening opportunities in resilient construction, coastal protection and renewables
Import dependence and energy costs	Seychelles imports about 95% of its energy, which raises operating costs	Port Victoria's deepening and renewable energy, which is VAT-exempt, lower costs over time and offer direct investment openings
Financial-services compliance	The IMF recommends stronger AML/CFT, beneficial-ownership and virtual-asset oversight	Use FSA-licensed, well-capitalised service providers and rigorous know-your-customer and beneficial-ownership

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
		practices

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Seychelles' risk profile is that of a well-managed, high-income small island state facing an external tourism shock. The 2026 slowdown came from outside the economy, as the Middle East conflict disrupted the Gulf air hubs through which most visitors travel, and it followed a record 2025 with growth of 5.8%. The policy response has been steady: the policy rate has been held at 1.75%, reserves cover about four months of imports, debt has fallen to 53.6% of GDP and the IMF programmes were completed in May 2026, with a Post-Financing Assessment due in December 2026. A nascent tourism recovery is under way and the shock has sharpened the focus on diversifying air links and the wider economy. Tourism investors should plan for route and source-market variability, while fisheries, port, renewable-energy and blue-finance investors can benefit from the diversification drive.

MARKET ACCESS

Seychelles is a member of the Southern African Development Community (SADC), the Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA), the Indian Ocean Commission and the WTO, a party to the Tripartite Free Trade Area and to other preferential trade agreements, and has bilateral investment treaties with several countries. Its main export destinations include France, the UAE and the UK. Europe is by far the largest source of visitors, accounting for about 77% of arrivals in early 2026, with Asia and Africa next. The deepening of Port Victoria to 16 metres is designed to cut shipping costs, reduce transit stops and strengthen its position in the Indian Ocean tuna industry.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Patrick Herminie)	Sets national economic policy and diversification priorities; the President was sworn in on 26 October 2025	Primary reference point for Seychelles' strategic direction and major projects
Seychelles Investment Board (SIB)	National single gateway for investment promotion and facilitation since 2004	Standard first point of contact for market entry, permits and incentives
Central Bank of Seychelles	Sets the monetary policy rate (1.75%), supervises banks and manages reserves	Relevant for monetary outlook, currency and banking-sector matters
Ministry of Finance	Leads fiscal policy, the budget and relations with the IMF and World Bank	Key counterpart for public investment, PPPs and fiscal incentives
Financial Services Authority (FSA)	Regulator for non-bank financial services, licensed funds and the SITZ	Essential for structuring funds, fintech and export-processing ventures
Seychelles Ports Authority	Owns and manages Port Victoria and is leading its deepening and extension	Counterpart for port, logistics and fisheries-services investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Seychelles Investment Board is the main channel for investor outreach and facilitation, working alongside local business associations. The World Bank, the European Investment Bank and the French Development Agency (AFD) are active financiers, including of the Port Victoria project, and the Global Environment Facility and World Bank backed the blue bond, making development finance a useful source of co-investment. Bilateral channels with the EU and France, the UK and the main tourism source markets are useful entry points, and the blue-economy community built around marine protection and blue-finance instruments offers a network for sustainable-investment partners.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Seychelles suits investors seeking a stable, high-income base with premium positioning: hospitality groups and resort developers able to plan for source-market variability; fisheries and seafood-processing investors building on

the tuna value chain; port, logistics and marine-services investors aligned with Port Victoria's expansion; renewable-energy and climate-resilience investors working alongside development banks; and financial-services firms using the FSA-regulated framework with strong compliance standards.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Seychelles Investment Board and confirm activity eligibility
Open dialogue with SIB to confirm how your activity is treated under the 2022 Economic Activities Regulations, including any equity caps, and which incentives apply.

STEP 2: Assess the tourism recovery and air-connectivity outlook
Track arrivals by source market and new air routes, and build route-disruption scenarios into hospitality and aviation-linked plans.

STEP 3: Explore blue-economy and fisheries opportunities
Review marine-protection rules, Port Victoria's expansion and the tuna value chain for processing, port-services and aquaculture openings.

STEP 4: Partner with development finance on energy and resilience projects
Approach the World Bank, EIB and AFD on co-financing for renewable-energy, coastal-protection and infrastructure projects.

STEP 5: Structure through the FSA framework with strong compliance
Use FSA-licensed providers and the SITZ where relevant, applying rigorous beneficial-ownership and anti-money-laundering standards.